MOUNTAIN BIKES · 5 MIN READ

Hardtail, full suspension and riding styles

Hardtail or full suspension

- **Hardtail**: suspension fork in front, rigid rear. Lighter, cheaper, less to service, and efficient on climbs.
- **Full suspension**: fork plus a rear shock. More grip, control and comfort on rough ground. Costs more, weighs more, and the shock and pivots need service.

Riding styles and travel

Travel is how far the suspension moves. More travel is not "better". It is for rougher, steeper riding and makes the bike slower on climbs.

STYLE	TYPICAL TRAVEL	BUILT FOR	IN OUR RANGE
Cross-country (XC)	100 to 120 mm	Climbing, speed, racing	Trek Procaliber and Supercaliber, Cannondale Scalpel and Scalpel HT, Polygon Siskiu D
Trail	120 to 150 mm	All-round riding, ups and downs	Polygon Siskiu T, Merida One-Twenty, Kona Honzo
Enduro	150 to 180 mm	Steep, rough descents	Polygon Collosus N

Our hardtails

Trek Marlin and Procaliber, Merida Big Nine, Polygon Cascade, Premier and Xtrada, Kona Mahuna, Kahuna, Fire Mountain, Cinder Cone and Honzo, Cannondale Scalpel HT. Most MTBs we sell are hardtails.

On the shop floor

- Ask where they will actually ride. If the answer is only city roads, a hybrid is usually the better bike.
- For a first mountain bike on fire roads and easy trails, a hardtail is the right call.
- Show full suspension when the customer already rides trails and wants more control on descents.

Remember these

- Hardtail: front suspension only. Lighter, cheaper, simpler.
- Full suspension: more control on rough ground, more cost and service.
- XC 100 to 120 mm, trail 120 to 150 mm, enduro 150 to 180 mm.
- More travel is for rougher riding, not a quality score.